AN ORIGINAL COUNTRY-HOUSE MYSTERY

THE LAST BELL OF ASHCOMBE HOUSE

PUZZLE SHEETS

Three linked code tasks and three investigation worksheets. Puzzles organize access; the evidence solves the crime.



1-6 INVESTIGATORS | 90-120 MINUTES | AGES 14+

An autumn storm. Six suspects. One unfinished announcement.

P1 / FIRST DIGIT

The house speaks first

Edmund wrote: "Beginnings spell the first number." Read the first letter of each line in order. Convert the resulting number word into one digit.

Frost silvers the silent lawn.

Oak leaves gather beside the stair.

Under the eaves the swallows sleep.

Rain keeps the evening waiting.

YOUR RECORD

First letters: _____
Number word: _____
First digit: _____

Why does this answer follow the instruction?

P2 / SECOND DIGIT

Put the labels in order

Use A, B, C and D exactly once. B stands immediately before D. C stands last. A stands after D. After arranging the labels, take the digit on the **second label**.

The letter is the label name. Its number is the value printed on it. You are not being asked to choose label B simply because B is the second letter of the alphabet.

Label	Printed value
A	6
B	8
C	2
D	1

YOUR RECORD

Order: ____ / ____ / ____ / ____
Second label: _____
Second digit: _____

Check every ordering rule before continuing.

P3 / THIRD DIGIT & UNLOCK

Use the corrected hour

Appointment note dated 16 October 1934:

"Telephone conference with solicitor: **seven in the evening, replacing nine**. Take only the corrected hour as the third digit."

This appointment occurred the previous day. It is separate from the 9:30 announcement on the night of the death. Use the 12-hour number written in the correction.

YOUR RECORD

Corrected hour: _____
Third digit: _____

Box code in order P1 / P2 / P3: ____ ____ ____

For facilitator-free play, use the folded check strip on the last page of Player Instructions. Reveal only the code check. If correct, open E09 in the evidence PDF.

If you need help, use the graduated hints in the Solution Guide. Reveal one hint at a time. Do not read the full answer or accusation pages.

P4 / TIMELINE WORKSHEET

Reconstruct the interval

Use E02-E05 and E12. Mark each entry as an observation, a claim or an inference. Do not invent an exact return time when nobody witnessed it.

Time	Person / place	Evidence & confidence
9:05		
9:08-9:10		
9:12-9:14		
9:14-9:18		
9:20		
9:22		
9:32		

Which unobserved interval matters most, and why?

P5 / SUSPECT MATRIX

Test your strongest alternative

For each person, record a motive, an opportunity and a physical connection. A blank is allowed. "Has a secret" is not itself physical evidence.

Suspect	Motive	Opportunity	Physical link
Celia Ward	_____	_____	_____
Nora Ashcombe	_____	_____	_____
Dr Felix Mercer	_____	_____	_____
Gideon Pike	_____	_____	_____
Martha Reed	_____	_____	_____
Arthur Bell	_____	_____	_____

Your strongest alternative suspect:

What supports that alternative? Which evidence weakens it?

Which clue is decisive only when combined with another clue?

P6 / FINAL CASE SUBMISSION

Make one supported accusation

Who caused Edmund's death?

Why did the confrontation occur?

Reconstruct the likely method and route.

List three evidence IDs and explain what each establishes.

Explain the strongest alternative and why you reject it.